

Grown-up's Playbook: The Journey to the Land of Youth

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

The Journey to the Land of Youth: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a braver tale than some, set in the misty Otherworld with its quiet pull to stay forever, but cleverness and kindness still win every time, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the home loch shore.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Cleverness** (quick thinking), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a twig or leaf for the sprig of oak, a small cake or token for the honey oatcake, and a ball of string or red wool. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Cleverness and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Cleverness).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. Across the mist, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Pook the Puca pops up and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze drifts off the loch, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Salmon of Wisdom blows a lucky bubble. All is well.
5	A sprig of oak for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

There is no foe in this tale and nothing to defeat. The only danger is the gentle pull of the Land of Youth, the temptation to stay forever in that lovely, forgetful place. The story is won not by beating anyone but by remembering home: the heroes gently help their half-forgetful friend recall the people and hearth waiting for them, tie the red wool so all can find the way back, and choose, kindly and together, to return across the mist. Let that choosing land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Journey to the Land of Youth: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Salmon's Riddle (Normal)

The challenge. The Salmon of Wisdom will not show the way across the Misty Loch until the players answer his riddle. He is fair and kind, and he wants them to do well.

The riddle. Read it aloud: *"I am not a bird, and yet I fly. I have no wings, yet I cross the sky. I cannot be caught and I cannot be kept, and I am gone the moment you turn to look. What am I?"* The answer is **the mist** (or a cloud, which the salmon accepts just as gladly, since both drift over the loch).

Intended solution. This is a thinking challenge of Cleverness and a little patience. Let the children talk it through together. The salmon accepts the right answer, and because he is kind, he also accepts a brave, thoughtful guess.

Fallback. If they are stuck, the salmon offers a clue ("You have walked through me all morning, and you cannot hold me in your hand"), or Pook the Puca whispers the answer from the reeds. A guess made bravely still earns the way across.

Stop 2: The Selkie's Crossing (Normal)

The challenge. Sorchia the Selkie has the only boat, but she is shy and a little lonely and will not meet the heroes' eyes. They must win her trust to be ferried across the mist. This is never won by force or by demanding.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Courage moment. Any genuine warmth works: a gentle word, telling her she is not alone, asking her name, or sharing the **honey oatcake**. It takes a little courage to speak first to a shy stranger. When the children are kind, Sorchia smiles, takes up the oars, and rows them across.

Fallback. If the children freeze or are unsure what to say, have Sorchia sniffle softly and murmur, "Nobody ever stops to talk to me." A single kind word melts her shyness. Sharing even a crumb of the oatcake counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Land of Youth (Hard, then no roll)

The challenge. In the ever-blossoming Otherworld the heroes find their lost friend, but the friend has half-forgotten home and gently urges everyone to stay forever. The pull to stay is the only danger, and the players may feel it too. There is nobody to defeat.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Cleverness moment. The clever, kind move is to give the friend their home back: talk warmly about the Roundhouse, the people who love them, the home loch at dawn, until the memory returns. Tying the **ball of red wool** at the water's edge is the cleverness that lets them all retrace the way back through the mist. When the friend remembers, everyone chooses, together, to return. After that choice there is no roll: the way home is simply taken.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have the friend pause and ask, very quietly, "Wait... was there someone who used to sing to me at night?" Any warm memory the children offer brings the friend the rest of the way back. The red wool guarantees nobody loses the path, however misty it grows.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the friend remembers and chooses home, Sorchu ferries them all back across the loch by the trail of red wool, the mist parts on a bright green shore, and **Danu the Kind** smiles down from the hills. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being clever, brave, and kind, and by keeping their promise to bring their friend home.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.